

US Equity Strategy Watch

S&P 500 above 8,000? It's possible: we outline how

Equity Strategy
North America

- ◆ We revise higher our year-end 2026 S&P 500 target to 7,650 on earnings strength...
- ◆ ... but could see the S&P 500 breaching 8,000 on a sentiment rebound in tech, AI, geopolitics, macro, etc
- ◆ Downside risks include tech earnings slowdown, energy supply shocks, a Fed pivot to hikes

The S&P 500 is back at record highs as tech stages a comeback, [US Equity Wrap](#), 4 May. A solid Q1 earnings season is also providing support. We're taking the opportunity to revise our 2026 index EPS estimates up by 8%, incorporating the latest quarterly results. We now expect 2026 EPS growth of 20% or USD325, with tech/Mag7 still the main drivers. With higher earnings expectations, we revise our year-end S&P 500 target to 7,650 from 7,500 previously.

While earnings remain supportive, sentiment is on shakier ground. The recent rally has been relatively narrow in breadth. Most stocks are still trading below their 52-week highs, suggesting scope for further upside if participation broadens. For that to happen, we'd look for a rebound in sentiment across tech, continued AI adoption, and an easing of concerns around geopolitics, trade, and rates.

A sentiment rebound could drive the S&P 500 past the 8,000 mark, in our view. We outline several potential paths for the index to notch another leg higher, including:

- ◆ **Tech re-rates** as IPOs set a higher bar for valuations
- ◆ **Laggards catch-up** as geopolitical and trade uncertainties fade
- ◆ **AI efficiency gains broaden** as margins expand
- ◆ **A "Goldilocks" backdrop returns** as long-term rates fall

We see each of these potential paths adding between 100–700 pts to the S&P 500. The clearest route to an additional leg up rests with tech: the sector (including hyperscalers) now represents over half of the S&P 500's market cap and more than 40% of index earnings. As a result, sentiment around tech is one of the biggest swing factors. We also see long-term rates as key. While the market has partially decoupled from long-term rate moves, the rate environment may become increasingly important as tech companies look to finance capex.

Downside risks: What could reverse the rally? Key concerns include sustained elevated oil prices feeding through to slower economic growth; a slowdown in tech earnings coinciding with elevated capex needs; and a hawkish Fed pivot if inflation re-accelerates.

Nicole Inui*, CFA
Head of Equity Strategy, Americas
Banco HSBC S.A.
nicole.inui@hsbc.com
+55 11 2802 3475

Alastair Pinder, CFA
Head EM and Global Equity Strategist
HSBC Securities (USA) Inc.
alastair.pinder@us.hsbc.com
+1 212 525 5972

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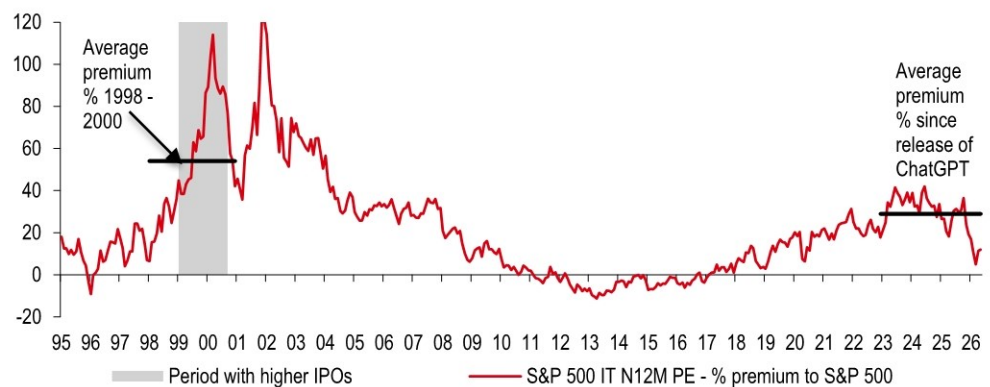
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Path to breaching 8,000 on the S&P 500

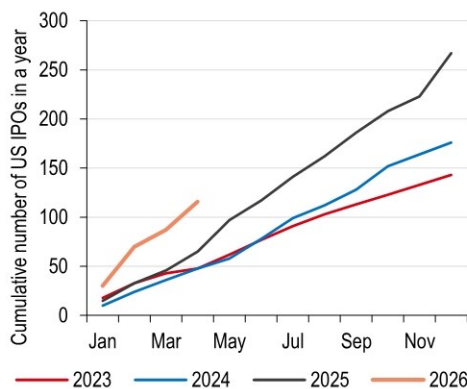
Tech re-rates: potentially adding 300-700+ points

Tech companies (including hyperscalers) now represent over half of the S&P 500's market cap and more than 40% of index earnings. As a result, sentiment around tech is one of the biggest swing factors for the S&P 500 performance. Valuations look reasonable, with the sector (IT and Mag 7) trading on a forward P/E of 25.8x and forward 12-month consensus earnings estimated to grow c31%. That said, valuations remain below prior highs: a return to those levels would add c360 points to the S&P 500. We could also see the sector trading at a premium to prior highs if IPOs of AI/tech stocks set a higher bar for valuations, potentially adding 700 points or more to the index. During the late-1990s internet boom, tech stocks traded at an average 50%-plus premium to the overall market; today, that premium is 12% (and below the average since the release of ChatGPT).

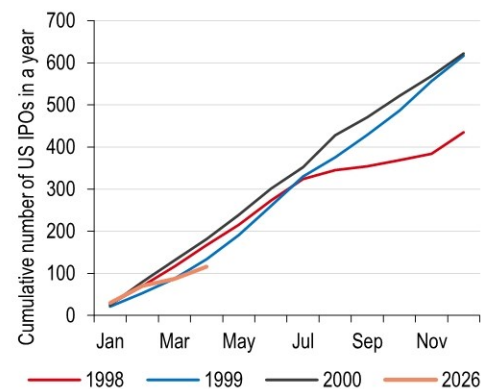
Tech premium off recent peak levels and well below dot com boom extremes



IPOs are picking up at the start of the year...



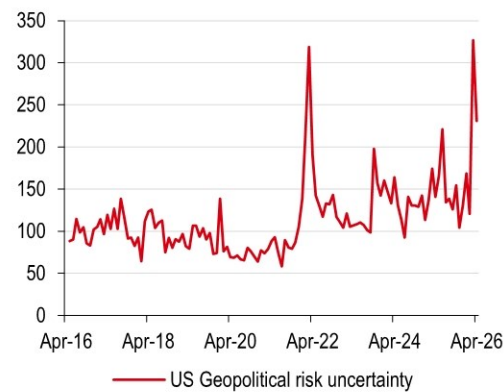
... but still lagging behind the IPO tech spree in the late 1990s



Laggards catch up: potentially adding 100+ points

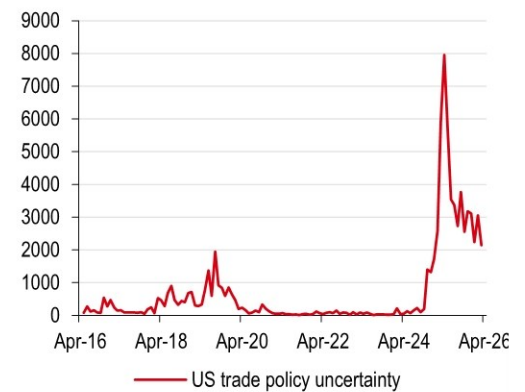
Geopolitical and trade policy uncertainty, while easing, remains elevated. Some sectors exposed to trade and geopolitical risks have underperformed. The consumer staples sector, for example, is feeling the hit to consumption from higher oil prices, alongside cost pressures linked to trade policy. Industrials is another area of vulnerability to trade, given the sector's reliance on imported inputs and exposure to supply-chain disruption, but overall, the sector is roughly flat since the Middle East conflict began as AI beneficiaries outperform. If uncertainty retreats to prior levels, these laggards (highlighted in chart below) could catch up, adding c130 points to the S&P 500.

US Geopolitical uncertainty remains at elevated levels...



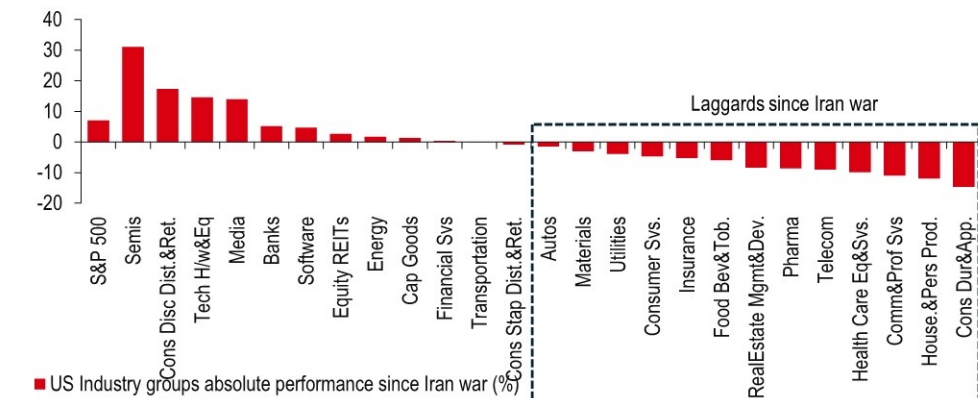
Source: LSEG Datastream, HSBC

...while trade policy uncertainty is falling but still at higher than historical levels



Source: LSEG Datastream, HSBC

US industry groups performance since the start of the Iran conflict

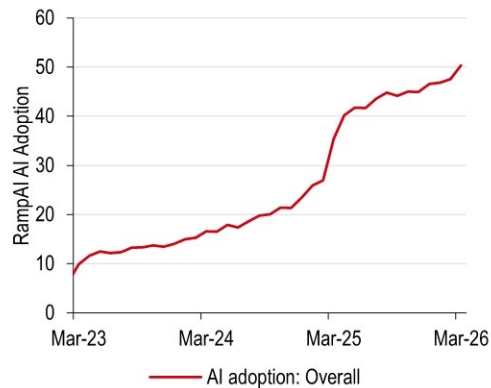


Source: FactSet, HSBC

AI efficiency gains broaden: potentially adding 200 points

Better sentiment around AI adoption and efficiency-driven margin improvement has been centered on tech so far, but as adoption widens, the market could start pricing in higher margins across other sectors—particularly those that are more labor-intensive. A rebound in sentiment around AI adoption and disruption would likely hinge on a re-rating, supported by clearer evidence of margin and profitability benefits. A major sentiment shift leading to a re-rating for AI adopters could add c200 points to the S&P 500 (assuming both software and financials re-rate).

AI adoption by US businesses is rising overall...



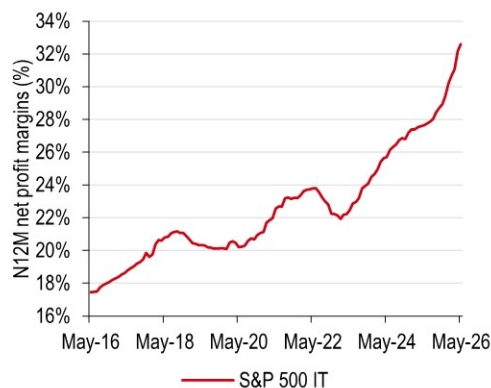
Source: Ramp AI, HSBC
 Note: Percentage of US businesses adopting AI

... with certain sectors increasingly reporting the use of AI



Source: US Consensus Bureau, HSBC

Net profit margins for the tech sector have risen exponentially...



Source: FactSet, HSBC

...while the rest of the index is also seeing margin gains but at a slower pace

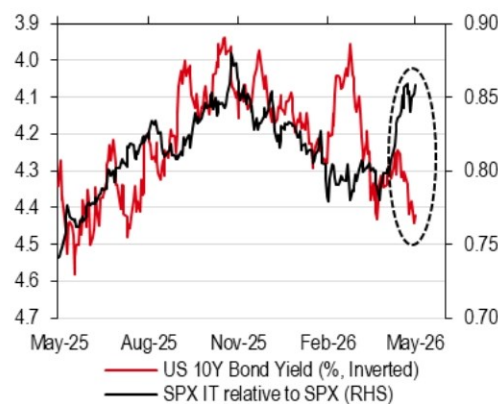


Source: FactSet, HSBC

Goldilocks backdrop returns: potentially adding 300 points

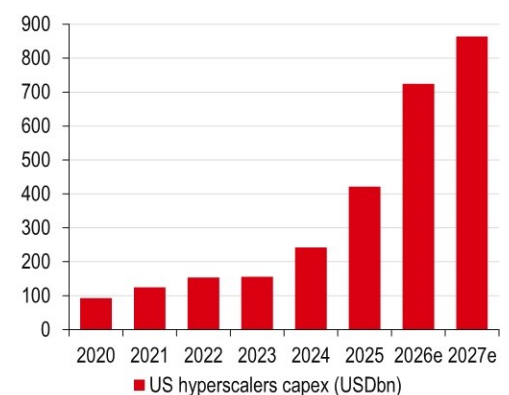
Macro sentiment improves – US 10-year Treasury yields are once again rising, getting close to the “danger zone” cited by our multi-asset team as the level at which risk assets tend to falter. Hawkish messaging from certain Fed members, alongside solid jobs growth and higher headline inflation pushed yields higher, though they’ve since eased somewhat. US mortgage rates also remain stubbornly above 6%. If yields move lower in a Goldilocks scenario – disinflation continuing towards 2% alongside resilient growth – equity valuations and earnings would likely lift, potentially adding c300 points to the S&P 500.

Tech has outperformed in spite of rising treasury yields...



Source: LSEG Datastream, HSBC

...but rates could become more relevant for sector performance as capex rises



Source: FactSet, HSBC Hyperscalers include Amazon (AMZN US, Buy, CMP USD271.17); Alphabet (GOOGL US, Buy, CMP USD397.99); Meta Platforms (META US, Buy, CMP USD616.81); Microsoft (MSFT US, Buy, CMP USD420.77); and Oracle (ORCL US, Buy, CMP USD194.59). Prices as of close on 7 May 2026

S&P 500 sensitivity table to bond yields and earnings growth

		US 10Y bond yield (%)					
		3.0	3.5	4.0	4.3	4.5	5.0
2026 EPS	11%	7220	7150	7090	7050	7030	6970
	15%	7460	7400	7330	7290	7260	7200
	17%	7580	7510	7446	7410	7380	7310
	20%	7820	7760	7690	7650	7620	7550
	24%	8060	7990	7900	7880	7850	7780
	26%	8180	8110	8040	7990	7970	7900

Source: LSEG Datastream, FactSet, HSBC Shaded cells represent S&P index target at 4% 10Y bond yields, Dark shaded cell represents current S&P target

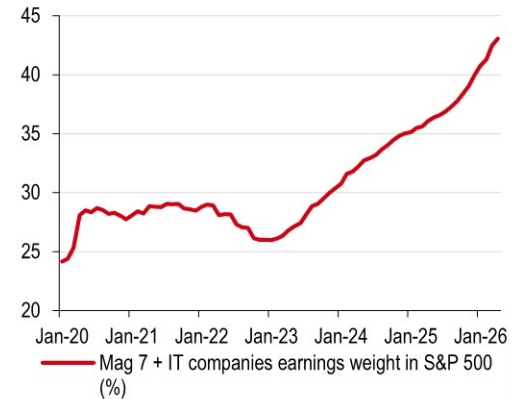
Tech and its relevance in the index

Mag 7 + IT market weight within S&P 500 close to all time high ...



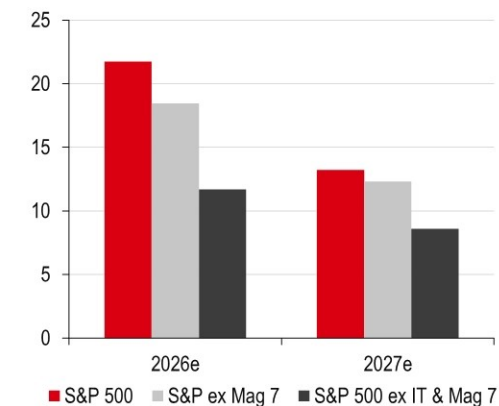
Source: FactSet, HSBC

...and its forward 12-month earnings weight steadily moves higher



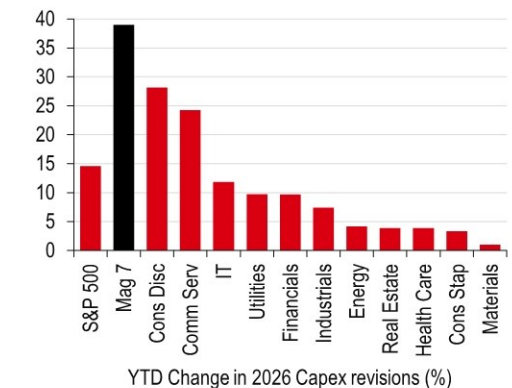
Source: FactSet, HSBC

Earnings growth expectations for the S&P excluding tech in the low double digits



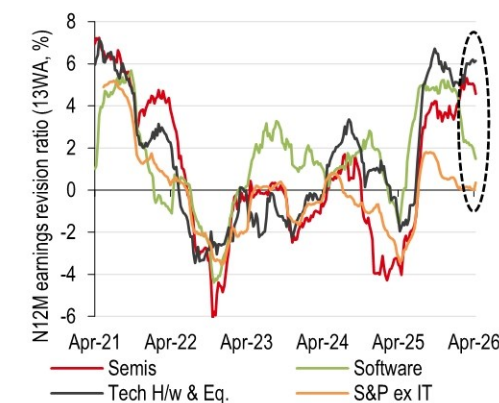
Source: FactSet, HSBC

Capex growth still driven by the Mag7 and tech cohort



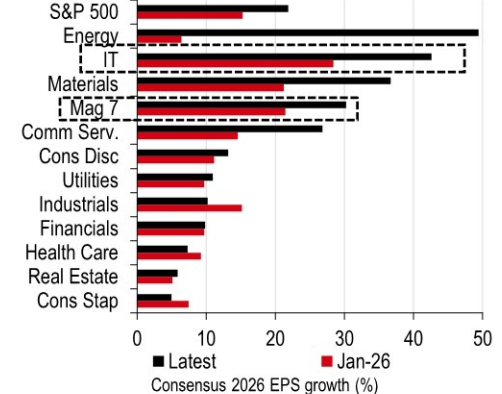
Source: LSEG Datastream, HSBC

Semis and Tech hardware & equipment seeing strong earnings revisions...



Source: IBES, LSEG Datastream, HSBC

...as IT and Mag 7 see one of the strongest earnings growth potential in 2026e



Source FactSet, HSBC

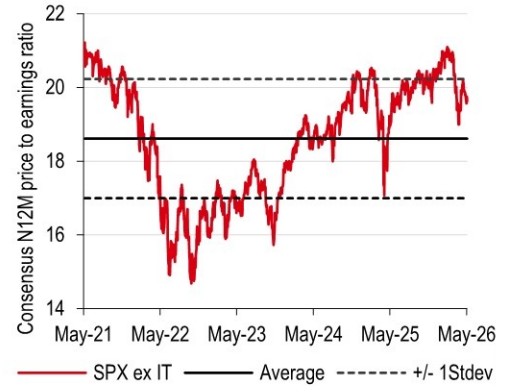
Valuations

S&P 500 trades at 5% premium to its five-year average



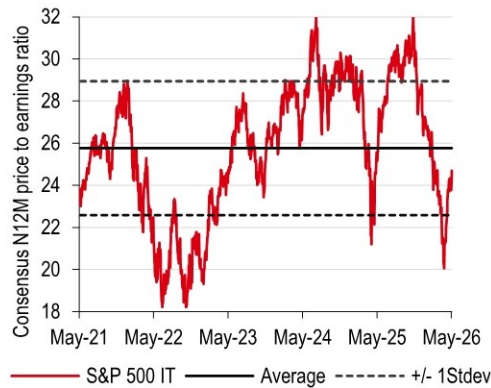
Source: FactSet, HSBC

Even when excluding tech, S&P 500 trades at a 5% premium to historical average



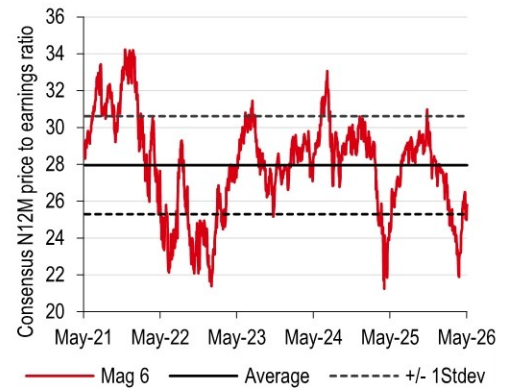
Source: FactSet, HSBC

Tech has de-rated, now trading at a 4% discount to historical average...



Source: FactSet, HSBC

...and the Mag 6 cohort as well trades at an 8% discount to 5-year average



Source: FactSet, HSBC

Mag 6 denotes Microsoft (MSFT US, Buy, CMP USD420.77); NVIDIA (NVDA US, Buy, CMP USD211.50); Amazon (AMZN US, Buy, CMP USD271.17); Alphabet (GOOGL US, Buy, CMP USD397.99); Meta Platforms (META US, Buy, CMP USD616.81); and Apple (AAPL US, Buy, CMP USD287.44). Prices as of close on 7 May 2026

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Juscelino Kubitschek Avenue, nº1909, 19º floor
 Vila Olímpia – São Paulo – SP – Brazil
 CEP 04543-907
 Telephone: 55 11 2802 3252
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